

Week 3 — Pulse Diagnosis

EAM310 · EAST ASIAN MEDICINE DIAGNOSIS I · VUIM SUMMER 2026

△ Quiz 2 — July 24, 2026

Class: Friday July 25, 2026 · 9AM–1PM

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REQUIRED READINGS — DUE BEFORE JULY 25

FCM CHAPTER 25 — MACIOCIA

- The Normal Pulse (平脈 Píng Mài)
- Three essential qualities: 胃神根
- 28 pulse qualities — full descriptions
- Clinical groupings by pattern
- Pulse qualities at individual positions

CAM CHAPTER 13 — CHENG XINNONG

- Normal pulse description
- 28 pathological pulse types
- Yin/Yang classification of pulses
- Pulse-taking method review
- Pulse qualities in disease

WEEK 3 LEARNING OBJECTIVES (CLO 1, 4, 5, 6)

- Describe the characteristics of a normal pulse
- Name the three essential qualities (胃神根) and explain each
- Identify the 28 classical pulse qualities by feel and name
- Classify pulses by Yin/Yang grouping (CAM framework)
- Explain what each pulse quality indicates clinically
- Differentiate easily confused pulse pairs (e.g., Wiry vs Tight)
- Apply pulse findings to the six positions bilaterally
- Integrate pulse with tongue for pattern differentiation

ASSESSMENT CALENDAR

Date	Event	Material Covered
Jul 24	△ Quiz 2	Week 2: Four Pillars, 8 Principles, Tongue intro, Pulse intro
Jul 25	Week 3 Class	Normal Pulse, 28 Pulse Qualities, in-class palpation practice
Jul 31	Quiz 3	Week 3 material — Pulse Diagnosis
Aug 7	MIDTERM + Journal 1–25	Weeks 1–4 comprehensive
Sep 11	FINAL + Journal 26–50	Weeks 6–9 comprehensive

IN-CLASS PRACTICE — WHAT TO EXPECT FRIDAY

PALPATION LAB

Week 3 includes hands-on in-class practice on pulse palpation. Come ready to:

- Practice three-finger placement on a partner (Cun/Guan/Chi bilaterally)
- Identify depth levels — superficial, middle, deep
- Attempt to name at least 3–5 qualities you feel in a live practice pulse
- Document your findings in your Pulse/Tongue Journal (entry counts toward midterm)

Pulse Positions & Normal Pulse

Hand	CUN 寸 (Distal · Front · Inch)	GUAN 關 (Middle · Gate)	CHI 尺 (Proximal · Rear · Foot)
LEFT	Heart / Pericardium	Liver / Gallbladder	Kidney-Yin / Bladder
Heart side	Small Intestine (deep) · Upper Jiao	Middle Jiao	Lower Jiao (L)
RIGHT	Lung / Large Intestine	Spleen / Stomach	Kidney-Yang / Bladder
Lung side	Chest · Upper Jiao	Middle Jiao	Lower Jiao (R) · Ming Men

Depth: Superficial = Yang/Exterior · Middle = Blood/SP-ST · Deep = Yin/Interior/KD · Three positions × Three depths = **9 classical positions**

NORMAL PULSE — 胃 WÈI · 神 SHÉN · 根 GĒN				
Quality	Feel	Reflects	Rate	4 beats/breath · 60–80 bpm · regular rhythm
胃 Wèi Stomach-Qi	Flowing, gentle, harmonious — unhurried	Digestive function intact; always present in the living	Width	Moderate — not too thin or wide
神 Shén Spirit	Soft with strength; regular; alive	Vitality of the Mind — good spirit = good prognosis	Depth	Strongest at middle depth — Qi/Blood flowing freely
根 Gēn Root	Clearly felt deep at Chi position	Kidney Essence intact — constitutional root	Strength	Moderate force — neither forceful nor forceless
			Shape	Smooth, even — ascending = descending
			Length	Felt at all 3 positions; neither too long nor short

6-STEP PULSE READING SEQUENCE			
①	Feel the pulse as a whole	Time of day	12 PM = Heart time → stronger Heart pulse (not pathology)
②	Check Spirit · Stomach-Qi · Root	Emotions	Running late → rapid; coffee → rapid/full; always ask
③	Three levels & three positions	Medications	Beta-blockers → slow/deep; tranquilizers → sluggish
④	Strength of the pulse	Constitution	Petite elderly woman may have a big strong pulse
⑤	Overall quality (if one exists)	Season	Wiry (Spring) · Flooding (Summer) · Hair-like (Autumn) · Stone (Winter)
⑥	Individual position quality		

Reference

Pulse (CN · Pinyin)	How It Feels	Clinical Indication	Key Combinations	
DEPTH				
Floating 浮 Fú Mài	Distinct at superficial; slightly fades deep — like wood floating on water	External Wind invasion; Yin deficiency (interior — floating-empty)	+Tight=Wind-Cold +Empty=Yin def ⚠	+Rapid=Wind-Heat
Deep/ Submerged 沉 Chén Mài	Only felt pressing to bone — stone thrown into a well	Interior patterns; Yang def (Deep-Weak); Pathogen in interior (Deep-Full)	+Weak=Yang def +Rapid=interior Heat	+Wiry=Blood stasis
Hidden 伏 Fú Mài	Press very heavily to bone — barely perceptible; deeper than Deep	Severe Yang def; extreme cold obstruction; syncope; painful obstruction	+Full=Qi/Blood stagnation +Empty=severe Yang def	
RATE				
Slow 遲 Chí Mài	<3 beats/breath (~40–60 bpm) — regular but leisurely	Cold pattern; Empty-Cold (Slow+Weak); Full-Cold (Slow+Full)	+Deep=interior Cold +Slippery=Cold-Phlegm	
Moderate 緩 Huǎn Mài	4 beats/breath; even, relaxed, slightly slow but not sluggish	Normal (if regular); Dampness; Spleen def; Late Summer seasonal	+Soggy=SP-Damp +Slippery=Cold-Damp	
Rapid 數 Shuò Mài	>5 beats/breath (~90–120 bpm) — rushing	Heat pattern; Full-Heat (Rapid+Full); Empty-Heat (Rapid+Floating-Empty)	+Floating=Wind-Heat +Slippery=Phlegm-Heat	+Wiry=LV-Fire
Hurried/Racing 疾 Jí Mài	>7 beats/breath (140–180 bpm) — extreme rapid with regular rhythm	Fire exhausting Yin; extreme Heat; severe condition	+Floating=severe Empty-Heat +Slippery=Phlegm-Heat	
STRENGTH / FORCE				
Full/ Overflowing 洪 Hóng Mài	Wide, forceful — rises strongly like ocean waves, fades gently	Full-Heat; Summer seasonal (NORMAL); Empty-Heat (Overflowing+Empty)	Summer=NORMAL +Slippery=Phlegm-Heat	+Floating=Wind-Heat+intense
Empty/ Deficient 虛 Xū Mài	Wide but forceless at all three positions — sense of emptiness	Qi deficiency; general deficiency	+Floating=Qi/Blood def +Slow=Yang def	
Minute/Faint 微 Wēi Mài	Extremely thin and forceless; seems to come and go	Severe deficiency of Qi and Blood; critical condition; near-collapse	+Rapid=Yin def+Empty-Heat +Choppy=Blood exhaustion	
Weak/Frail 弱 Ruò Mài	Forceless, deep and thin — only felt at deep depth; lost with pressure	Yang deficiency; Blood deficiency	+Choppy=Blood def +Slow=Yang def	
SHAPE / TENSION				

Pulse (CN · Pinyin)	How It Feels	Clinical Indication	Key Combinations
Wiry 弦 Xián Mài	Taut, long, forceful — like a guitar/guqin string	Liver disharmony; Pain; Phlegm; Spring (seasonal — NORMAL)	+Rapid=LV-Fire +Slow=Cold in LV channel +Tight=Blood stasis
Tight 緊 Jǐn Mài	Tense, twisted like a rope — bounces left and right under finger	Cold pattern; Pain; Food retention	+Floating=ext Cold +Deep=int Cold Wiry vs Tight: Tight snaps side-to-side
Slippery 滑 Huá Mài	Smooth, rounded, quick — like a pearl rolling on a plate; oily	Phlegm; Dampness; Food retention; Pregnancy	+Rapid=Damp-Heat +Slow=Damp-Cold +Big=Phlegm-Heat
Choppy/Rough 澀 Sè Mài	Rough, uneven, hesitant — like scraping bamboo with a knife	Blood stasis; Blood deficiency; Yin deficiency; Body Fluid exhaustion	+Wiry=Blood stasis +Weak=Blood def +Slow=Cold+Blood stasis

28 Pulse Qualities (cont.) + Seasonal & Combinations

Pulse (CN · Pinyin)	How It Feels	Clinical Indication	Key Combinations
LENGTH			
Long 長 Cháng Mài	Extends beyond Cun and Chi positions; smooth and straight	Heat patterns; Liver excess; generally positive sign if soft	+Rapid=int Heat +Wiry=LV disharmony +Slippery=Phlegm-Heat
Short 短 Duǎn Mài	Cannot be felt in all three positions — absent distally/proximally	Qi deficiency; Qi stagnation; Stomach-Qi def	+Choppy=Blood stasis+Qi def +Rapid=severe HT-Blood def
WIDTH / SIZE			
Hollow 芤 Kōu Mài	Wide, soft — edges felt but center hollow; like a scallion stalk	Hemorrhage; forthcoming hemorrhage (+Rapid); Yin deficiency	+Rapid=Yin def+Empty-Heat or hemorrhage +Empty-Soggy=Essence depletion
Fine/Thin 細 Xì Mài	Very thin but clear and distinct — like a fine thread	Blood deficiency; Dampness with severe Qi def; Yin def	+Rapid=Yin def+Empty-Heat +Wiry=LV-Qi stagnation
Soggy 濡 Rú Mài	Superficial, thin, forceless — like cotton floating on water; weakens with pressure	Dampness; Qi/Blood deficiency; Spleen/Stomach def	+Slow=Damp-Cold +Rapid=Damp-Heat +Fine=SP-Qi def
Firm/Confined 牢 Láo Mài	Deep, taut, long, wide, forceful — only at deep depth; cannot be felt superficially	Blood stasis; Interior Cold; Pain; masses	+Tight=internal Cold +Choppy=Blood stasis
Scattered 散 Sǎn Mài	Wide, superficial, forceless, irregular — disappears completely on pressure	Collapse of Original Qi; critical condition; loss of Kidney foundation	+Slow=severe Qi/Yang def +Rapid=severe Blood def+Empty-Heat
RHYTHM (IRREGULAR)			
Hasty 促 Cù Mài	Rapid with irregular stops — urgently restless; like a man suddenly falling	Severe Heat; Heart-Qi def; Heart-Fire; obstruction by Phlegm/stasis	+Overflowing=HT-ST Heat +Wiry=LV/HT Fire

Pulse (CN · Pinyin)	How It Feels	Clinical Indication	Key Combinations
Knotted 結 Jié Mài	Slow with irregular stops — like a knotted rope	Cold obstructing; Qi stagnation; Phlegm; Blood stasis; Yin excess	+Choppy=Blood stasis +Slippery=Phlegm retention
Intermittent 代 Dài Mài	Regular pauses at fixed intervals — after pause pulse resumes	Serious internal organ disease; Heart problem (Western); critical sign	Most serious irregular pulse Organ failure indicator
Moving 動 Dòng Mài	Rapid and slippery — forceful at middle; like a bean bouncing; no head or tail	Shock; anxiety; fright; Pain	+Rapid=Heat +Slippery=Qi/Phlegm def +Empty=Blood depletion

Season	Pulse	Why / Note
Spring	Wiry 弦 Xián Feb 4–May 4	Yang Qi arising but Yin obstructs → tension. Too wiry = pathology
Summer	Flooding 洪 Hóng May 5–Aug 6	Yang fully uninhibited, spreads outward. Flooding = NORMAL — don't call excess
Autumn	Hair-like 毛 Máo Aug 7–Nov 6	Yang Qi desiring restraint. "Like elm pods falling" (Su Wen). Light + empty = normal
Winter	Stone-like 石 Shí Nov 7–Feb 3	Yang stored deep. Sinks like a stone. Harder to feel = NORMAL in winter

SIX CLIMATIC QI → PULSE · SHANG HAN LUN	
Pathogen / Stage	Pulse
Wind	Floating
Cold	Tight, contracted, deep
Summer-Heat	Floating, vacuous
Dampness	Soggy, slippery
Dryness	Short, hasty, rough
Fire/Heat	Restless, rapid
SHANG HAN LUN STAGES	
Taiyang	Floating
Yangming	Flooding or Long
Shaoyang	Wiry
Taiyin	Moderate (middle depth)
Shaoyin	Faint and thin
Jueyin	Thin, tendency to expire

EAM Diagnosis Notes

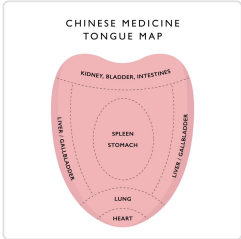
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July 25, 2026

PATTERN NAME	DISEASE CATEGORY	WEEK / QUIZ

ETIOLOGY	ORGAN SYSTEM	DATE

CLINICAL ESSENTIALS · TONGUE · PULSE · TREATMENT PRINCIPLE



COLOR / COAT / SHAPE



Wrist	CUN 寸	GUAN 關	CHI 尺
L HT/PC		LV/GB	KD-Yin
R LU/LI		SP/ST	KD-Yang

QUALITY / OVERALL



